

TIMES SQUARE RED TIMES SQUARE BLUE



afterword by Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick

Samuel R. Delany

Times Square Red, Times Square Blue

SAMUEL R. DELANY



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**For
Bruce Benderson**

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Building, crouched between the apartment buildings either side. (The Cameo/New Adonis finally became the Playpen peep show—in pink, blue, pink neon: “Live!” “Live!” “Live!”) In the seventies the Capri was Al Goldstein’s Capri, owned by the publisher and editor of *Screw Magazine*, his name proudly at the top of the marquee. But Goldstein unloaded it by the time the seventies turned over into the eighties, under the first pressure of the developers to start the “renovation” of the area.

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I often thought about taking photographs in the movies. But I never did. Verbal accounts such as this are what remain.

Furthest down the block from the Capri, the Venus was generally a little too scroungy even for me. The drug activity there was often so high as to obliterate the sex activity. Still, on and off through the years, it provided me with a couple of memorable regulars. Gary was one, a handyman who worked at a Catholic church on Tenth Avenue. A lanky, affable guy with a brown ponytail, he impressed me as someone with very fixed habits who, as long as he was within them, was comfortable. And he always seemed comfortable in the theater. I first met him up at the Hollywood when he was about thirty-seven, but their patrolling and monitoring turned him off, so he moved down to the Venus. Regularly he brought in his two forty-two-ounce bottles of beer, generally to sit in the last three or four rows of the orchestra on the right as you came in, settling back to wait for one of three older guys to service him, me among them. He had a regular girlfriend, he claimed, who’d introduced him to the pleasures of getting things shoved up his behind when he had sex, but her overall sexual appetites simply weren’t as high as his. That’s why he came to the movies. He liked two or three fingers thrust deep up his asshole while you sucked his rather thick, cut seven inches, but he was a little reticent about explaining this to new guys. So he pretty much stuck to the three of us.

If two of us showed up at the same time, he would take firm and polite charge: “No, *you* stay—and I’ll see you the next time, all right?” We never argued—at least I didn’t, since after the first six months I became pretty much his first choice, a fact of which I was exorbitantly, if quietly, proud. When Gary came to the theater, he was there between three hours and all day. About half that time he wanted sex. The other half, he just wanted to sit and talk quietly, occasionally taking a swig from the beer bottle, which he kept down on the bare concrete between his running shoes. By and large he did not share.

I say there were three of us. Over the years, however, there must have been a few replacements, for several times I was away for as long as a school term. But my returns rarely got a larger comment than, “Hey, how’re you doin’? I *thought* that was you when I saw you come in. I haven’t seen you for a while.” Sitting up in his seat, he’d frown through the lenses of his gold framed glasses, fiddling with the buttons of his jeans with a big knuckled hand, zipping closed his fly, which had apparently been open. “Watch my beer for me, okay? I’m gonna run downstairs and take a piss. When I come back, we can do some stuff.” If you wanted to talk about where you’d been or what you’d been doing, he was intelligently interested. “But,” as he said several times, “I don’t pry.”

Gary was not profligate with information about the other men who serviced him. But once, when I came by and an older fellow with short white hair, a blue sweater, and white jeans got up from the seat beside him and turned up the aisle to leave, he told me as I sat down in the man’s place, “He’s a really nice guy. I’ve known him for years. Really nice—a doctor. He’s interesting, too. The only thing is, I can’t come with him. He’s okay for the first hour or so. But after that, when I’m ready to do the deed, I have to send him away and wait for you or someone else who can get me off—or do it myself.”

Gary sometimes spoke of a friend with whom he had a regular eight o’clock Thursday night chess date. Sometimes, toward seven, as he got ready to leave the theater, he’d say, “Well, I’m off to play chess”—another activity he could never

interest his girlfriend in. Gary was good conversation and good sex. Our before and after talks were largely about books and magazine articles. Once, when, leaving him, I happened to drop my keys on the floor, he found them five minutes later and went through some three days of considerable effort to get them—successfully—back to me. When I saw him last, about two or three months before the theaters shut down for good, he was celebrating his forty-sixth birthday by spending the day at the porn films.

“Good God, Gary! You’re forty-six? That means I’ve known you six, maybe seven years now!”

“No, professor, I think it’s a little longer.” He was one of only three people in the theaters who called me by that nickname.

Another regular who spent more time at the Venus than the Capri was Tommy. All but homeless, small and muscular, he collected scrap metal off the street and sold it to the yards around the docks. For most of the years I knew him Tommy wore a sleeveless denim jacket and a studded leather band on one wrist. In the winter, one or two hooded sweatshirts turned up under the denim; in summer, a T-shirt or, often, nothing. He had a carrot-colored ponytail and a red bushy beard even larger than mine. I first ran into him back in the seventies at the Cameo. In the world of quick, perfunctory sex, he was an extremely affectionate man, so that it was always a pleasure to trick with him. (I mean, with hands, arms, hips, Tommy made love to your head. Nor did he mind necking.) Sometimes his conversation was a bit incoherent (and grew more so over the years), consisting of complaints, more or less cheerfully offered, about various of his relatives, the intricate tales about whom he always assumed I would remember from the last time we’d spoken. Once, as far back as the seventies, when I brought a newspaper into the movies with me, and, as we were talking, I showed him some article or other, he turned to me under the wall light where we were sitting and said, “No, you got to read it to me.” And it hit me: Tommy didn’t read or write. We last had anything to do with each other perhaps a month before the theaters closed for good—that bushy red

hair was more than half white. And for a three- or three-and-a-half-year period, toward the end of the eighties, in the middle of every third or fourth session with Tommy suddenly he'd urinate all over himself. "Some guys really get off on it," he told me, once. "Uncle Phil, now—Afterwards, they'll even go down to Robbins, buy me a new pair of jeans, and bring 'em back here to the movies, so I can change into something dry. Other guys, they'd get all twisted out of shape—soon as they feel my jeans get hot and start drippin', they jump up and run out of the theater! That really tickles me. I mean, I actually get off on it! But I can't do that *too* much, you know? You know my Uncle Phil? My Uncle Phil I told you about him? Not my cousin Mary. Huh? Oh—or they won't let me into the theater"—another reason Tommy preferred the laxer and funkier Venus, especially in its end days, to the Capri.

Between '84 and '90 I was without any live-in significant other. Early in that time, I remember, when I ran into Tommy in the Venus (and his tales about his bemusing relatives were a little more coherent than later), I invited him over to my house for breakfast. "See," he explained, "I gotta have breakfast about four-thirty. My aunt—yeah, my aunt. She started that with me. 'Cause if I ain't on the street and working by six, everybody else gets all the good pieces." So, yeah, he'd come over at four-thirty—and the night before I outdid myself at Zabar's, getting stuff to grace our homefried potatoes and sunnyside-up eggs: fresh fruit, smoked salmon, toasted bagels, cream cheese, some good coffee. . . .

Tommy never showed.

When I saw him again, his excuse—whatever it was—was reasonable. We set it up again. Again he didn't show. I soothed myself with the observation that a good breakfast and an early start were good for *me*, anyway—even if I had to eat alone. Indeed, all five times he stood me up turned into wonderfully productive days at the word processor. Though the last two (by now I knew enough not to make any special trips to Broadway, unless it was just for myself), I'd have been surprised if he'd arrived. If he turned up, we'd eat what I had around. And, of course,

he didn't. In the theater, though, he was always pleased to see me. And the sex was always good.

A glib wisdom holds that people like this just don't want relationships. They have "problems with intimacy." But the salient fact is: These *were* relationships. In Tommy's case, in Gary's, and in several others they were relationships that lasted years. Intimacy for most of us is a condition that endures, however often repeated, for minutes or for hours. And these all had their many intimate hours. But, like all sane relationships, they also had limits.

Eventually (four or five years later) I asked Tommy why, whenever I'd invited him over, he'd blown me off.

"Huh? I don't know." Sitting there beside me in the theater, he didn't sound uncomfortable with the subject, so I pressed it. "Well," he said finally, "maybe it's Joey, my cousin. And maybe it's that when I first started comin' to the movies, a couple of guys gave me their address and told me to come over. A few times, I went—they weren't home. Or they'd given me the wrong address; the wrong phone number. Just like Mary—she'd do something like that. Did I ever tell you about my uncle? What was his name—?"

"Phil?"

"No, not him . . . Anyway. One time there wasn't even any building at the place the guy told me to show up. So I just figured talking about it, planning it, that was the fun part. The rest, though, that was all bullshit." (I wondered if, relatives aside, that's what Flaubert had had in mind in the closing chapter of *Sentimental Education*?) "I probably figured it was some kind of joke you were pullin' that I didn't understand but wished you wouldn't do it. I went along with it, you know, while we were in the theater, I guess, tryin' to be nice. But you *really* wanted some guy like *me* to come over to your house . . . ? Damn—I think you're probably just jokin' now. Naw, I wouldn't do that; go where anybody in here told me to. *Un-uhn!* I might even get hurt or somethin'."

. . .

I think of the middle eighties in the sex movies as the “Great Winnowing,” from crack and AIDS—with crack very *much* the leading villain of the two. If I gather the tragedies, most of the ones I remember come from that period: ’84, ’85, ’86 . . .

Pietro was a shy, beefy, nineteen-year-old Italian, whom I first met in the Cameo, when he was six months in the country and living with his sister in Brooklyn. Five or six times I took him from the theater for pasta at Pizza King over on Ninth Avenue. Several times I brought him down paper bags full of clothes (which he needed, desperately), and which he could just squeeze into. I would see him wearing them, over the next two, three, four weeks, sometimes in the theater, sometimes walking in the street. Not overly swift, but not particularly slow either, he was the quintessential nice, friendly, naive kid.

Hustling? The first time I met him, he didn’t even *know* the word in English.

By the time he was twenty-five, however, a lot of that beef had been pared away by coke. He was in and out of the hustling bars in the neighborhood like a figure in a fast-motion slapstick sequence—Trix, Hombres, (the old) Cats (on Eighth Avenue), O’Neill’s Backyard. The shyness was long gone, replaced now by an almost belligerent friendliness, necessary if you’re to be any sort of successful insurance man—or hustler. A year or two later, I recall a conversation at the bar: “Hey, do you ever see Pete—that short-haired, blond Italian kid with the accent?”

“Oh, man—that kid’s dead. You didn’t hear about that? It was about four months ago . . .”

There was Kevin, twenty-one and dark, dark black, who, when I first met him (also in the Cameo) wore striped engineer’s overalls and a train engineer’s cap. His big hands, his full mouth, and his general masculine gentleness (Kevin lifted weights years before the buffed and pumped-up nineties) made him an exemplar of male beauty that still, in memory, remains powerful for me. Like Pietro, he was another regular in from Brooklyn. On the third time we made it, he told me, “I won’t go with just anyone. Only special people—like you. Because

you're nice." He wanted to be a musician, though I was unclear what instruments, if any, he played.

By 1985 though, this teak-colored, muscle-bound little powerhouse (he wasn't much taller than Tommy) was scooting all around the Port Authority, doing dope deals up at Gate 335, passing bags back in the underpass across from Hom-bres ("Cause the police are just through the aluminum doors twenty feet away—and that's the *last* place they think you be doin' it!"). When he would run into me in the theater now, it was, "Lemme hold two dollars, man, so I can run down to the bathroom and get somethin'. Then I'll be back!" and he would—about every three minutes, with the identical plea, as many times as you'd supply the two bucks.

In '88 or '89, the last time I saw him, I was on my way to the Habana-San Juan Dry Cleaners, recently moved around the corner across from the post office on Eighty-third Street. Really, it was like the heaviest-handed Concluding Moral Resolution from some Dreiser or Dos Passos novel. Kevin was coming along, picking through the garbage cans . . .

The power was gone. The gentleness was still there, though. After our wistful three minutes of conversation (he was homeless, he was dirty and ragged, he wasn't doing too good, but . . . well, maybe things would get better), he shambled off with it to somewhere . . . I haven't seen him since.

Why *this* one should be sadder than the others, I'm not sure. But it strikes me that way. When, after a near-dozen-year reign as the largest and most successful of the West Side hustling bars, the Haymarket closed in '81, Joey (mother Polish, father Irish and Italian) was twenty-four and a two-hundred/three-hundred-dollar-a-night hustling success, with more drugs and watches and diamond rings and coke than he knew what to do with. There was a whole lot of talk about revamping Times Square—tearing everything down on Forty-second Street, building these big office towers in place of the theaters. And the whole neighborhood was shutting down and being bought up by land speculators. The high-class hustling business

was all heading over to the East Side, where Rounds would shortly begin its legendary reign on Lexington Avenue. But some grow more dependent than others on familiar institutions. Joey had worked out of the Haymarket since he was seventeen and there with false I.D. His clients were all West Siders. His drug connections were all West Siders. The Haymarket had made him the success he was. Besides, his mother lived on the East Side, and he wanted to stay away from her. So while the business moved east, he remained. He had friends he could crash with—now on this couch, now on that—when it got rough. He'd always been a good guy. So, a few times he'd paid for his crash space with sex. ("They say the first time you do that, you ain't a hustler no more. You're just a faggot. Well, who the hell wants to be a hustler *all* his life?")

In preparation for the longer and longer delayed architectural renovation, the drugstore shut, the comic book shop moved, the dry cleaners closed—and two years later saw Joey living on the street. But he was still a good-looking guy, an enthusiastic raconteur, with hands as big as Kevin's (although, unlike Kevin, Joey was *not* a nailbiter), dark hair, pleasant smile—but with enough sense not to dwell too much on the glory days now two, now three, now four years in the past. When I first saw him one evening as I was walking with a friend past Trix, he was standing in front of the bar talking to some other hustlers, one hand deep in the hip pocket of his jeans, playing with himself while he joked and chatted.

Playing with his dick in his pants was what he was doing when I saw him a day later, standing alone by the doorway just down from the firehouse—and I started a conversation: "Do you always stand around pulling on yourself like that?" I asked, thinking I was being daring (breaking a level, as therapist/client-speak would have put it in those days).

"Oh, yeah. Sure. Most of the time, I don't even realize I'm doin' it. When I used to hustle, man, that's what *all* my johns would start talking to me about. But it feels good—I like to do it. It keeps me relaxed. And it's always makin' me new

friends. So why should I stop? You remember the Haymarket, man? It was right there. See? The front's all cinderblocked closed now . . ."

Joey's nickname was Joey-Who-Needs-a-Bath, to distinguish him from several other guys named Joey, then out on the streets. (He could talk about drugs with guys who worked out of Trix, but the bar wouldn't let him in. He was too dirty.) He'd gotten the name in the first year after the Haymarket shut, when his requests for crash space were usually couched, "Can I come up? Man, I really need to take me a bath!" which, because most people used showers, sounded a bit quaint. "But that's what my mom always said when I was a kid. She meant shower, but since it was in a bathtub, she *said* bath. And I said it, too. It's just like *you* always say 'ice-box' instead of refrigerator. I bet people laugh at you for that, too. But it probably just means you had a real icebox when you were a kid."

"That's right. And yeah, they do," I told him, "sometimes."

By now, though, in the two years he'd been on the streets, the requests for baths/showers were no longer part of his "self-presentation." Joey-Who-Needs-a-Bath was just a grubby guy, always fiddling with his dick down in his pocket.

For about a month and a half in '84 or '85, Joey and I had a regular Thursday morning meeting at ten-thirty, when we would go into the Capri together, at the end of which I would give him ten dollars, and he would run off to get some crack.

And I learned why he had been such a successful hustler. "I know guys are always telling you this, and you think it's a load of bullshit. But I'm really straight. I mean, I can get off with guys—any way till Sunday. But to do it I always have to *think* about girls. That's why I like goin' in the movies, so that I can get some good heterosexual stimulation from the screen." Though I think a certain reticence is appropriate when discussing it, at least *one* reason Pietro and Kevin were memorable is that both, uncut, were hung (in a simile) like mules. Joey was not. On a scale of small, medium, and large I fall directly on the border line between the latter two. Joey was just under the middle of medium. But, sitting beside me in the Capri, talking, with his cut dick out, he explained, "I *love* to come, man. I mean I

love to come more than anything in the *world*. And I like people to *see* me come. I like them to *know* I'm coming. I like them to *hear* me come. I like them to love it that I'm coming, too! Now: You want to suck me? You want me just to jerk off? Or what?"

Between the time I'd first talked to him and now, Joey had developed a sore on the back of his left hand that was probably infected and was suppurating through its bandage. So I said: "Why don't you jerk off?"

"Sure. That's easy." Over the next twenty-five minutes, now losing his pants, now his shirt, now his shoes, next his socks, now standing and growling, now sitting all but in my lap, thrashing and flailing his free arm, now practically down between the seat and the back in front of him on the floor, he groaned and quivered and pumped till, lying back in the chair, ass up off the cushion, grinning and panting, he sprayed across his quivering stomach and began to rub his mucus around and over himself. "Oh, man . . . ! Oh, shit . . . ! Oh, fuck . . . !"

Three of the five people who had gathered in the aisle to watch, applauded.

When, finally, Joey began to sit up, collect his clothes, and put them back on, he asked, "Anybody want to contribute five bucks? I mean, you gotta admit, that was a good show, huh?"

One older gentleman gave it to him. "Thanks, pops." It went into his jeans pocket with the ten from me.

There are as many different styles, intensities, and timbres to sex as there are people. The variety of nuance and attitude blends into the variety of techniques and actions employed, which finally segues, as seamlessly, into the variety of sexual objects the range of humankind desires. Certainly one of the necessary places where socializing and sexualizing actually touch for, dare I call it, health or just contentment: We do a little better when we sexualize our own manner of having sex—learn to find our own way of having sex sexy. Call it a healthy narcissism, if you like. This alone allows us to relax with our own sexuality. Paradoxically, this also allows us to vary it and accommodate it, as far as we wish, to other people. I

don't see how this can be accomplished without a statistically significant variety of partners and a fair amount of communication with them, at that, about what their sexual reactions to us are. (However supportive, the response of a single partner just cannot do that. This is a quintessentially *social* process, involving a social response.) When Lacan says, "One desires the desire of the other," self-confidence is, generally speaking, the aspect of it desired. That sexual self-confidence (though it's not what's usually meant by the words) is what Joey had; and it was very attractive.

I was the one, though, who, after a month or so, missed our assigned Thursday meeting. Hustlers are just not my particular thing. (Somebody could probably expand that into a five-hundred-page psychoanalytic study as to why. But while I've liked any number of hustlers as people, it's down among my secondary or even tertiary preferred forms of sex.) When I ran into Joey on the street, he was all professional concern: "I was worried about you, man. I mean, I was hoping that nothing had happened to you or anything. The money I could always get from *somebody*."

I made my excuses—then, responsibly, suggested we put off our next meeting. (One of the good things about hustlers is that usually they tend not to take such things personally.) And we were just passing friends north of the Deuce.

Oh, we had a couple more encounters. The last, most pleasant, messiest (on my part) and loudest (on his) was in a doorway on Forty-eighth Street, one night when I'd had a couple too many. Afterwards Joey put me on an uptown bus, then tramped off over the icy street into the December dark. It was only five bucks that night.

In '86 or '87 one February evening at (the Eighth Avenue) Cats, a black drag queen with exquisite crimson nails and a red-blond wig frowned at me over her drink, then asked, "Are you Chip?"

"That's right."

"Did you know a kid out here named Joey? They used to call him Joey-Who-Needs-a-Bath?"

"Sure."

"He used to talk about you, a lot. I thought, because of the beard—and the glasses—you might be him. You know he died two weeks back."

I turned around. "No, I *didn't*!"

She nodded. "They found him in a lobby behind the stairs in a building on Forty-eighth—frozen to death. They think he had a heart attack or something. Oh, that boy was *just* the sweetest! I used to let him stay with me all the time. On my couch. He was always so nice." Now she leaned over and put her hand on my wrist. "I have never known anyone who could get into sex more than he could. I mean, that boy *loved* to come!"

"Yes, I know."

"I mean—" a bit loaded, she was just on the other side of discretion—"I have a few little kinks, myself, and he was always the world's most obliging lay. You see, I like to get fucked in unusual places. Once, when he came by looking for a place to stay, I threw him into the shower, dried him off, stuck him in an old suit jacket of mine from the last time I had a straight job—it just about fit him—and took him to the Rainbow Room. You ever been to the Rainbow Room, honey?"

"On the top of Rockefeller Center? Yes . . ."

"And I made him fuck me in the stall in the ladies' room." She sat back now. "And that boy was *not* quiet when he came. Another time—" she turned and pointed toward the door—"right across the street there in Beefsteak Charlie's. You ever been in there? They got the back room, which is three steps down from the front, and off around the side. They close that at nine-thirty, before they kick everybody out at ten. Well, honey, we went right in there—and he did me out on one of the tables. I mean, half the waiters was in there, eggin' us on. I don't know what the manager thought—if he knew. And don't *tell* me about the Staten Island

Ferry at midnight—" She shook her head. "That boy was *so* talented. I don't think he'd had his twenty-ninth birthday yet." She shook her head once more. "Frozen to death in a hallway—with a heart attack. I think the drugs must have weakened his system."

The period had its AIDS tragedies ("You remember your little hustler friend Mark?" a redheaded hustler, Tony, in black leather pants and black leather jacket, who specialized in heavy S&M topping, told me one evening, elbow to elbow with me at the bar in Trix. "Two weeks before he died, we all got together and sent him home—upstate, to Binghamton. He wanted to die at home. So we sent him there. And he did.") and jailhouse cases (blue-eyed, black-haired Paul, who came out of Rikers Island correctional facilities, back to the Venus, with the worst case of crabs I've *ever* seen; and hulking German John, whom I met on the strip when he was twenty-one [with his own movie tales: "Once this guy takes me into the Cameo, and he has me take my sneakers off and sit in the row behind him and put my feet over the seats in front. Then he plays with them, and kisses them, and fondles 'em and stuff—and they were pretty damned powerful, too, 'cause I'd been sleeping on the street for almost three weeks by then"] and who, eighteen years later, *still* writes and phones me now and again from jail in Southern California, where he's been serving time for the last six years. And scruffy little "Sundance" McLoughlin, missing a forefinger from a motorcycle accident, a regular in the back balcony of the Capri, who last phoned me from jail in Toronto).

But not all tales end in premature death or incarceration. For most, indeed, we never learn an end at all.

Maybe thirty-six, Bobby lived in Oliver Sacks land. Homeless, he collected cans and frequented the Capri for about three years in the late eighties. Among our dozen encounters in the theater, I took him home with me some three times. Once, in the midst of sex, suddenly he insisted that I "fuck him like a whore!" Bobby didn't know where he was from, what his last name was—and was unclear on his first. ("Bobby" was just the one I picked for him; but, in his vague, friendly way, he

responded pretty much to any name you addressed him by.) The last time I saw him, sometime in '87 or '88, sitting on the island in the middle of Broadway, with his green plastic garbage bag of empty beer and soda cans against his knee, without shoes and wearing a pair of dress pants so tight he could not close the zipper, Bobby—like the soldier of Arete—avowed with as much sincerity as he had the second, the fourth, the sixth time we'd met, and, indeed, all three times he'd come to my house, that he had no memory of me whatsoever.

There was Al, a chain-smoking, six-foot, 180-pound Italian welder from Brooklyn, in his late thirties, with a classic micro-penis: three-quarters of an inch in diameter and not quite an inch long, when erect. "And *this* didn't pop out till I was about fifteen, sixteen, and got all this damned hair—when my damned balls finally came down." From the sleeves and collar of his blue work shirt, his arms and neck were a veritable rug, his jaw a steel-stubbed sheet in the screen's flicker. (Al's testicles were normal/small—and hairy. Both were there, though they'd descended, he explained, late in his adolescence, three months apart.) "You know, they were gonna turn me into a *girl* when I was born—the doctors? But my mom said, 'No fuckin' way!' Thank God I had some skin, or nobody would've known *what* I was!" Al's masturbatory technique was to sit in the first row, legs out, pants open, and flick the side of his thick thumb back and forth over his diminutive knob. "When I first come in here, it was just for the damned movies. I didn't even realize the kind of shit that went on here till I'd been comin' in for a couple of weeks. And, I mean, a lot of the guys who make out here got those fuckin' horse cocks, anyway—you see 'em sittin' around beatin' off when you walk in. Hey, did you see that black guy in here yesterday, sitting right over there, down from me in the first row? I swear, he shot all over the damned *screen*—really, he hit the movie screen! Look, it's still up there—see? I don't even think people can *piss* that far! But don't you know, I got me a regular little fan club in here. There must be about six or seven guys come in, they just think I'm the hottest thing since sliced bread. About two hours back, I had me three of 'em in here *fightin'* over me, man!" Chuckling, Al lit another

cigarette, then reached down to brush ashes from his pubic hair. They'd fallen there from his last cigarette.

And there was Arly, who'd lost a leg at five when his crazed, drunken father had flung him under an oncoming subway ("You know, sometimes I still dream about them subway cars rushing over my head, man!") and who played the drums in his mother's Columbian Pentecostal church. I met him when he was twenty-one or twenty-two and he would come in to settle in the Cameo's balcony. Good-looking, friendly, and extremely agile on his one-stick crutch, for the first three times I talked to him, he claimed to be too tired for sex. Finally I'd assumed he just wasn't available, when, the next time he passed me in the balcony aisle, suddenly he seized my arm to explain in a low, excited voice (like someone taking a breath before plunging under water to perform some intricate task), that he was more highly sexed than most men, and thus anyone who sat with him but stayed only through the first of his orgasms would (in his words) "drive me crazy, man. It makes me wanna *die*—" he dragged down my arm at the emphasis—"if I can't come three or four times, you know? I mean, I wanna die. So if you wanna do me, man, you got to promise to stay with me till I come at *least* three times, huh? All right? Okay?" And so we began a regular relationship in which, well . . . *that's* what he did. Those first three orgasms usually took him about forty-five minutes. In a more relaxed, two- or two-and-a-half-hour session, he'd make five, and often six. "Now I'm relaxed, man. Maybe I'll get off again, or, if I go home, man, I won't feel like I wanna die, see?"

Arly's and my friendship *did* get to the point of going to each other's houses. When I first visited him, he lived in an incredibly filthy apartment in an incongruous squatters' building on West End Avenue at Ninety-eighth Street, his floor strewn inches deep with girly magazines around his corner mattress. Two years later, he moved back into his mother's neat, green-and-yellow-and-pink-and-purple-and-orange-and-blue frilly project apartment, with poodle and flamingo mirrors and colorful religious statues. A couple of times Arly came to my five-flight

walk-up writer's digs. With his one leg and single-stem homemade crutch, he took my steps three at a bound.

"Arly, how do you *do* that?"

"See, I don't *weigh* as much as you guys do, by thirty, thirty-five pounds! I can go a lot faster. Besides, I live on the eighth floor, man—our elevators *never* work. So I get a lot of practice."

In '86 I remember running into him one afternoon at the Capri.

Arly was sitting under a light, crutch against the wall and sports jacket folded over the seat in front of him (after several years of panhandling on the corner of Forty-seventh Street, in the diamond sellers' neighborhood, one of the shop owners, after talking with him, had taken him in and given him a job), his pants open, jerking off. Now, at thirty, Arly was good-looking, with a hard body, and a solid ten inches, uncut; and while a few people were put off by the missing leg, he seldom lacked for takers. He demanded endurance. But he was attractive enough—and big enough—that he could afford to be choosy. As I slid in beside him, he grinned up at me and grabbed my arm to pull me down: "Aw, this is good, now—I got the man here who *really* knows how to do it!" You'd have to be a habitu   to understand just how fine a greeting like that can make you feel. Arly leaned closer. "Hey, you know: I almost got me in trouble, earlier."

"What happened?" I asked, sitting—and settling my hand between his legs, moving into his open fly to rub the irregular flesh of his stump, while it flexed and shifted in response. He enjoyed that. I did too.

"I'm here this morning at ten o'clock, and I want to get off a couple of times by myself, you know, so I can relax. This guy is sitting right there in front of me—I'm not payin' him no mind. I mean, I don't even see him. And I get to work. Well, *you* know how I shoot! And I ain't done it for a couple of days. Man, it goes over the seat back there, gets all on his neck, in his hair . . . ! The next thing you know, he's up in his seat and wants to have a fight! I say, hey, hey, hey, hey, hey—man, look! I'm a cripple! You don't wanna fight me! Look at me! See? I only got one leg!"

But I'm holding my crutch—you know, I made it myself. It's metal. It can do some damage, if it has to. Guys are always hassling cripples."

"Did anything *happen*?" I asked, suitably surprised.

"Naw. He backed down. I told him I was sorry. He's a lot of mouth, though. Anyway. Finally, he got up and stomped off. It was an accident." Arly was obviously tickled by the whole thing. "But I swear. I didn't do it on purpose. I just didn't see him, you know?" His hand went up to the back of my head to urge me down.

In July of 1987, at a pre-theater dinner in Greenwich Village with two of her oldest friends, on her way to the lady's room at Gavin's restaurant, my mother suffered a massive stroke that kept her at St. Luke's Hospital for ten months, then put her in the Park Shore Manor nursing home, paralyzed on her right side and unable to speak, write anything other than incoherent progressions of letters, or respond directly to verbal instructions. In this state, wheelchair-bound and incontinent, she remained for the final eight years of her life.

The incident, as do such medical catastrophes—with hospital visits, medical consultations, visits with lawyers in a cluttered upstairs Harlem office, conservatorship papers, trips down with lawyer and doctor to the city courthouse for competency hearings in the courtroom off the echoing second-floor rotunda, and, yes, the resultant emotional strain—simply excised, as with a pair of sheers, a productive ten months from my sister's life and mine.

I am convinced that, in Kafka's *Die Verwandlung*, Gregor Samsa's transformation stands for just such a catastrophe, fallen on one or another family member: a stroke, a crippling accident, insanity (possibly Kafka's own tuberculosis), an irrevocable change that does not (immediately) kill but leaves, rather, an incomprehensible creature to be dealt with one way or another by all who remain, a creature wholly alien yet somehow recognizable in fifty little ways—a hand gesture, a shake of the head, a sudden single phrase ("I know") muttered thirty-seven times, a smile, a moue—as the subject he or she once was.

A week after my mother's transfer to the Park Shore Manor—a six-block walk beyond the last stop on the L train at the far end of Canarsie—on my way home from my second visit, I dropped in to the Capri.

And found Arly.

He'd come three times already (he explained), so, after forty-five minutes (in which he came three more), we fell into conversation, and I began to tell him some of the trials of the previous year. When I told him about the visit to the nursing home, he declared, "Hey, why don't I come out and see your mom with you? When's the next time you're goin'?"

I said, "Huh?"

"No, I'm serious. I'll go out with you, next time you have to go—and visit with your mother. It'll be better for you, if you got company on that long subway ride, won't it?"

". . . Huh?"

He punched me in the shoulder—playfully. "I'm not kiddin'. I'd really like that. When you goin' again?"

"Huh . . . ?" I repeated. "You want to come with me—all the way to *Canarsie*?"

"Sure. I *love* that stuff, man. Goin' to visit people in the hospital, in nursing homes. That's fun. I told you—my mother had this church? That's what we used to do all the time when I was a kid. Go around and visit sick people. Man, that was the most fun I ever had in my *life*! They were real interesting, those people. Old people—they could tell some stories—"

"My mom doesn't talk any more," I said.

"That's okay. It's still fun. When you gonna go again?"

"Uhh . . .," I said. "In two weeks. On Thursday. My sister goes every week. I've been trying to go every other week."

"Good," he said. "You just tell me where you wanna meet."

So, two Thursdays hence, we met at my stoop and rode down to Fourteenth, transferred to the lonely L, and took the train to the end of the line to get out on

the bustling Brooklyn avenue. On his single crutch, Arly lurched along beside me through the June sun to the Park Shore.

In my mom's room on the seventh floor, Arly became a one-legged whirlwind, straightening her pillow, putting things right on the table beside her bed—the crutch was left in the corner now: in such small spaces he found it easier to maneuver without it—telling her how well she looked, smoothing up her covers, reassuring her that she'd soon be well. Mom's sluggishness over the first fifteen minutes of our visit gave way to a bright-eyed attention, as if by osmosis she absorbed his energy and his cheerfulness. Clearly she was enchanted with him, and grinned and nodded and followed him with her eyes. Several times she even laughed. We took her downstairs in her wheelchair and outside on a forty-minute tour of the neighborhood, stopping for ice cream, which, back in the grassy yard in the back of the Manor on our return, first I, then Arly fed her with a white plastic spoon.

"She likes music," I said. "Can you sing?"

"Naw," Arly said. "I play the drums, but I don't sing too good—" then sang with me anyway: "She'll Be Comin' Round the Mountain," "When the Saints Go Marchin' In," and "Jesus Loves Me," Arly in Spanish, me in English, as, in her orange robe in the wheelchair, her paralyzed arm belted with white Velcro into its fiberglass brace, Mom "la-la-ed" along.

If you're looking for an analogue from literature, it's not Gregor's sister playing the violin outside her transformed brother's door; it's the young peasant who tells the meaningless jokes as he lets Ivan rest his feet on his shoulders, the only position in which the dying man can be comfortable, in *The Death of Ivan Ilyich*.

Over the years Arly'd mentioned both coke and crack. But now, in the late eighties, when I ran into him in the theater he usually had a hip bottle of Dewars with him. A couple of times, holding it up and looking at it in the light from the theater's wall lamp, he told me, "Man, scotch is what saved me from being a crack-head!"

And once, already tipsy, he came ringing my doorbell with a quart bottle already half empty. While we were sitting on my maroon living room rug, talking about one thing and another, suddenly he reached out, pulled me to him, and, with his eyes closed, kissed me for ten or fifteen uninterrupted minutes—which he'd certainly never done before in the theater!

When we broke, he said, "Now—I ain't never done *that* before! I mean with a guy. *That* was interesting. First I was trying to pretend like your beard was pussy hair or something. But I didn't even really have to do *that*!"

Good stuff, that Dewars.

In 1984 I'd written a novel with a character based on Arly, about whom I'd tried to imagine what it would be like running into after a decade's absence. The reality was less dramatic, more unusual, and probably—for some—more predictable.

In the summer of '93, when I was sitting out on my stoop reading, around the corner came a rotund fellow on a crutch, with natty tan slacks carefully pinned up on his missing leg, a single polished loafer (I seem to remember that he wore no sock; but possibly the one he wore was the same coffee-and-cream tan as his skin), hair thinning on the top, and his arm around an extraordinarily attractive and fresh-looking black-haired woman. Arly must have been forty, even forty-two by then. No, it hadn't been ten years since I'd seen him, but it *had* been at least three.

"Hey, man. I was *wondering* if I was going to run into you today. This is my wife, man—isn't she beautiful?" (The woman couldn't have been more than twenty-two or twenty-three.) "We been married about six months now—well, she ain't *really* my wife. But we been livin' together—in my mother's apartment. For six months. My mom, she went back to Colombia, so I got the apartment now. She don't speak no English, but she *loves* to take care of me—" he gave me a quick wink—"almost as good as you used to. Isn't she beautiful, man? She's just twenty years old. Isn't she the most beautiful woman in the *world*?"

I'll tell you, you could make a case for it.

With her arm around Arly's shoulder, her bright dark eyes, her white blouse and printed peasant skirt, she looked like a girl in love.

"And she *cooks* . . . ? Man, can she cook!" Arly patted his stomach, of which there were thirty or so pounds more since I'd last seen him. "She got me lookin' like a house. But she loves me like this. She knows all about me, everything I need, how to take care of me."

"So I guess you don't go to the movies any more?"

"Oh, no, man. I don't need that shit now. That place is nasty. I don't like to go there no more. Yeah, I still got me a few videos. But she even lets me watch *them*, you know? She watches 'em with me. She's perfect, man! I mean, isn't she *perfect*?" He pulled her nearer. "You guys gonna have to come up to our place for dinner. How about that, you hear?"

My significant other had just walked up to the stoop: I introduced Dennis to Arly and to the perfect young woman whose name we hadn't been told.

"Yeah, you guys come on up. I'll call you—I still got your number. You'll come on up for dinner. I mean, you wanna taste some *real* good food, the way she cooks . . . ? You gotta come up—for dinner."

"Thanks, Arly. Sure."

With her shoulder under his arm, Arly turned and, on his crutch, made his way with her back to the corner.

I haven't seen them since.

Despite moments of infatuation on both sides, these were not love relationships. The few hustlers excepted, they were not business relationships. They were encounters whose most important aspect was that mutual pleasure was exchanged—an aspect that, yes, colored all their other aspects, but that did not involve any sort of life commitment. Most were affable but brief because, beyond pleasure, these were people you had little in common with. Yet what greater field and force than pleasure can human beings share? More than half were single encounters. But some lasted over weeks; others for months; still others went on a cou-

ple of years. And enough endured a decade or more to give them their own flavor, form, and characteristic aspects. You learned something about these people (though not necessarily their name, or where they lived, or what their job or income was); and they learned something about you. The relationships were not (necessarily) consecutive. They braided. They interwove. They were simultaneous. (Several times I saw Gary in the morning and Arly and/or Tommy in the afternoon.) These relationships did not annoy or in any way distress the man I was living with—*because* they had their limits. They were not the central relationships of my life. They made that central relationship richer, however, by relieving it of many anxieties.

V

Mulling back over it, generally the denizens of the Venus seemed a bit more colorful than those from the Capri: the extremely handsome Hispanic young man who would rush into the theater at ten after five, obviously just off from work, drop down in the first row, pull out his genitals and a *serious* looking pair of handcuffs, bind his scrotum up in them, their hasp ratcheting through the catch, masturbate, and then, putting himself and the whole metallic contraption back in his pants, rush from the theater equally fast (as far as I could tell, he must have kept the key at home); or the various fellows—those who did not lean suddenly forward to spill on the back of the chair before them or on the cement floor in front of the cracked red seat—who, a moment after coming, would fall asleep, pants still gaping, genitals still loose, semen glimmering on their brown or black bellies in the light from the screen; the several midgets; the countless drag queens; the dozen who, off in the darkest parts of the theater, would strip completely naked before masturbating. . . .

Between the Venus and the Capri was the Eros I: Unlike the Venus and the Capri, the Eros showed gay porn films. After performing on stage, male dancers